TURNING THE TIDE

The government is now planning to revive old waterways to build a robust inland and maritime transportation network

By ***Shwweta Punj***

During pre-Independence times, major navigable rivers were an important means of transportation in northern and eastern India. But trade was largely confined to the Gangetic waterways. With the advent of the railways, the focus on waterways saw a steady decline. Though transportation through rivers is cheaper, India's freight movement in this mode is less than 1 per cent, compared to China at 24 per cent and the US at 9 per cent. Currently, there are 111 National Waterways in the country—106 were notified in 2016 as National Waterways, adding to the list of existing five.



PEOPLE'S WATERCOURSE
Ferries on the Hooghly river in Calcutta, 1940s